



HTC Vive McLaren edition

Formula One fans rejoice as HTC and McLaren's partnership brings them the HTC Vive Pro McLaren Edition. <https://dgit.in/dec18-127-1>



US says avoid Huawei

The US government have asked ally countries to stop using Huawei equipment due to security fears. <https://dgit.in/dec18-127-2>

A DIGITAL GRAVEYARD

The number of digital profiles belonging to the dead is increasing every day. While there are numbers to back it up, a much simpler argument is that people are simply too lazy or unaware of the proper measures to take for the deletion or removal of an account. As a result, even with newer digital profiles being created every day, there will come a time when the dead on the internet will outnumber the living. Is there a way to put a year on that? Turns out there is (with a degree of approximation).

A study by Carl J. Öhman from the University of Oxford and David Watson from the Alan Turing Institute sheds light on some interesting areas pertaining to digital death. About putting a number on the dead profiles on social media, they pick Facebook as a choice due to its popularity. Their approach fixates on two scenarios – one in which there's a global freeze on people joining Facebook (to estimate the floor) and one in which Facebook maintains its current growth rate to reach 90% penetration of a given group (to estimate a ceiling). This gives a range for the actual number to fall within. In the results, the first scenario leads to a maximum of nearly one in ten profiles belonging to someone who has passed away, while the second one leads to a significantly higher percentage of three in ten.

In either of the cases, the number of dead on Facebook doesn't exceed that of the living within this century. But even in the conservative alternative of the first scenario, the number of dead on Facebook is in hundreds of millions – mainly comprising of countries like India due to high population and the US due to high penetration rates. Needless to say, online death is well on its way to become a mass phenomenon. Like most such phenomenon, it comes with its own set of ethical implications.

THE ETHICS OF THE DIGITAL DEAD

There is undoubtedly a personal story involved in every single profile of the deceased that lies on Facebook today and will lie in years to come. However,

taking all of these profiles together in the bigger picture paints a different possibility. In Facebook's case, it becomes the singular owner of this data, making itself a vast repository of historical information that could be invaluable to future historians. If you take machine learning models into account, that often use big data repositories to learn about, among other things, human behaviour then it becomes even more evident how a data reserve like this could be very important to future generations.

As a result, there's a need to preserve this data. However, for a company or corporation like Facebook, what makes data "worth preservation" is its ability to contribute to the profit of the company. The profiles of the users who have passed away might serve this purpose. People looking to mourn those users will visit their profiles, generating hits, clicks, exposure and traffic – all things that Facebook can profit from. There's also the previously mentioned possibility

of this data being used to train software and retrieve historical insight. However, when either of these possibilities turns non-profitable, it would be logical for Facebook to delete this data, or at least modify it to be profitable.

However, this data should be compared to archaeological finds and the way we evaluate them. A diary from the Medieval ages won't be valuable because of the data it holds, its value will lie in other factors that define its existence. Additionally, as Orwell points out in 1984, those who can control the data about the past can also control the way we perceive it.

So what about you? Do you want to live on forever in the belly of a data center somewhere, or would you rather your social accounts be deleted forever when you're gone? 

SOURCES:

- dgit.in/DDS1
- dgit.in/DDS2



PC, Laptop
Tablet, Mobile
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